

seek out experiments in their environment. Their persistent drive to ask the question “why” can, however, drive many parents to frustration at the best of times. And even for those parents who wish to support the self-education of young children the costs can be discouraging. The damage done by children in their exploration of the world also has a monetary cost which all parents can’t afford. So in the case of computing and programming, even if a parent wants to encourage their child to explore and discover, a home computer worth tens of thousands of rupees may not be worth the risk. But what if it wasn’t that expensive? And what if it was scalable in cost over time? A teaching tool that grows with the child’s imagination - that is what the Raspberry Pi proves to be.

The success of the Raspberry Pi isn’t because it is the fastest or the most powerful or the most easy to use microcomputer. It’s because it is the blank canvas that teaches people how to paint. While it was originally intended to foster an interest in programming and computing among children, it has proven that the broader population of adults is just as curious when it comes to computers. While almost everyone familiar with a computer has used it - either as mobile devices or PCs - they haven’t ever had the opportunity to explore what makes it work. The computer has always been a magic box with a beautiful facade through which user experience is oriented. But as people are discovering with the Raspberry Pi, computers can be reduced to understandable concepts which can be physically worked upon to achieve a customised results.

The explosion in Do-It-Yourself or DIY projects around the Raspberry Pi has demonstrated that with a barebones setup, people of different means and interests, can create their own learning environments. The highest priority of needs with a learning tool isn’t its novelty but its utility - and that is where the Raspberry Pi is able to differentiate itself from its competitors. While other micro pocket-sized computers come in packaged boxes, with wireless features and higher specifications, they take away the learning opportunities regarding how to implement wireless systems independently. The Raspberry Pi puts together the basic set-up of a computer and leaves it in the hands of the user to do with as they please. And to help them is a vast array of open source DIY projects available to explore - from simple ones that allow for a computer in your TV to something as creative as a robotic assistant.

The killer feature of the Raspberry Pi in this context is the low buy-in cost. For even the most financially conservative user, the price tag of the cheapest